

Materia Medica III – Wind-Extinguishing (Calm Liver Wind) Herbs

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Overview

Wind-extinguishing herbs **calm Liver wind, anchor ascendant yang, clear Liver heat, and open the channels**. They are used for dizziness, vertigo, tremors, convulsions, seizures, stroke sequelae, and headaches related to **Liver wind, Liver yang rising, or Liver fire**. Accurate differentiation between **excess vs. deficiency** is exam-critical.

General Characteristics (High-Yield)

Attribute	Description
Taste	Salty (often bitter/acrid secondary)
Temperature	Cool to cold (some neutral/warm)
Channels	Liver (primary)
Core Actions	Extinguish wind; anchor yang; clear heat

Global Cautions (Exam-Critical)

- Use cautiously with **Spleen/Stomach deficiency and cold**.
 - Many substances are **animal or mineral** → sourcing, toxicity, and preparation matter.
 - Distinguish **excess heat wind** vs. **deficiency wind** before selection.
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Wind-Extinguishing Herbs – Quick Reference Table

Herb	Nature	Channels	Core Exam Keywords
Ling Yang Jiao	Cold	LV	Strongly extinguishes wind; clears heat; brightens eyes

Herb	Nature	Channels	Core Exam Keywords
Gou Teng	Cool	HT, LV	Extinguishes wind; pacifies yang; hypertension
Tian Ma	Neutral	LV	Calms wind; stops spasms; headaches
Quan Xie	Warm, toxic	LV	Strong wind- extinguisher; opens channels
Wu Gong	Warm, toxic	LV	Opens channels; stops severe spasms
Jiang Can	Neutral	LV, LU	Eliminates wind- phlegm; benefits throat
Di Long	Cold	LV, LU, BL	Clears heat; opens channels; arrests wheezing
Shi Jue Ming	Cold	LV	Anchors yang; brightens eyes
Mu Li	Cool	LV, KD	Anchors yang; softens hardness; prevents leakage
Dai Zhe Shi	Cold	HT, LV	Anchors yang; redirects rebellious qi
Bai Ji Li	Neutral	LV	Soothes LV; dispels wind; itching
Jue Ming Zi	Cool	LV, LI	Clears eyes; anchors yang; moistens bowels
Zhen Zhu	Cold	HT, LV	Generates tissue and heals skin when used externally

Líng Yáng Jiǎo 羚羊角

Cornu Saigae Tataricae | *Saiga antelope horn* (often substituted)

Nature & Flavor: Salty, cold

Channels: Liver, Heart

Primary Actions

1. **Strongly extinguishes Liver wind; stops spasms**
2. **Clears Liver heat; cools blood**
3. **Brightens eyes**
4. **Anchors Liver Yang**
5. **Clears heat toxin**

Key Indications

- High fever with convulsions
- Acute Liver wind from extreme heat
- Childhood seizures or spasms
- Severe Liver fire with headache and red eyes
- Warm febrile disease with delirium or mania

Cautions/Contraindications

- Rare and protected animal product (often substituted clinically)
- Use cautiously in deficiency conditions

Preparation

- Cook separately, then combine with decoction.

Dosage

- Decoction: 1–3 g
- Powder: 0.3–0.5 g

Exam Pearl

Ling Yang Jiao is the strongest wind-extinguisher, making it the Best herb for Liver wind from extreme heat.

Gōu Téng 钩藤

Ramulus Uncariae cum Uncis | *Uncaria stem with hooks*

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, cool

Channels: Heart, Liver

Primary Actions

1. **Extinguishes wind; alleviates spasms**
2. **Clears Liver heat; pacifies ascendant yang**
3. **Lowers blood pressure**

Key Indications

- Tremors and seizures
- Liver yang hypertension
- Headache with red eyes
- Pediatric convulsions

Cautions/Contraindications

- None major; gentle herb

Preparation

- Add near end of decoction; cook ≤10 minutes

Dosage

- 10–15 g (max 30 g)

Exam Pearl

Essential for hypertension due to LV yang rising.

Tiān Má 天麻

Rhizoma Gastrodiae | *Gastrodia rhizome*

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, neutral

Channels: Liver

Primary Actions

1. **Calms Liver; extinguishes wind**

2. **Stops tremors and spasms**
3. **Calms Liver yang; treats headaches**
4. **Dispels wind-damp**

Key Indications

- Headache and dizziness
- Wind-phlegm headaches
- Stroke recovery
- Convulsions

Cautions/Contraindications

- May cause mild sedation

Preparation

- Standard decoction.

Dosage

- 3–10 g

Exam Pearl

Tian Ma treats both heat- and cold-type wind

Quán Xiē 全蝎

Scorpio | *Scorpion* (toxic)

Nature & Flavor: Acrid, neutral

Channels: Liver

Primary Actions

1. **Strongly extinguishes wind**
2. **Stops severe spasms**
3. **Opens/unblocks channels; relieves pain**
4. **Dissipates nodules**

Key Indications

- Severe convulsions

- Tetanus
- Facial paralysis
- Chronic migraine

Cautions/Contraindications

- Toxic
- Contraindicated in pregnancy

Preparation

- Often used powdered.

Dosage

- 2–5 g decoction
- 0.6–1 g powder

Exam Pearl

Strong internal wind herb used when spasms are severe.

Wú Gōng 蜈蚣

Scolopendra | Centipede (toxic)

Nature & Flavor: Acrid, warm

Channels: Liver

Primary Actions

1. **Extinguishes wind; treats severe convulsions and spasms**
2. **Opens/unblocks channels; alleviates pain**
3. **Disperses nodules; Attacks toxins**

Key Indications

- Severe convulsions
- Lockjaw
- Toxic nodules or carbuncles
- Severe headaches

Cautions/Contraindications

- Toxic
- Contraindicated in pregnancy

Preparation

- Decoction or powdered form.

Dosage

- 1–3 g decoction
- 0.6–1 g powder

Exam Pearl

Stronger than Quan Xie for severe spasms.

Bai Jiāng Cán 僵蚕

Bombyx Batryticatus | *Stiff/Sick silkworm*

Nature & Flavor: Salty, acrid, neutral

Channels: Liver, Lung

Primary Actions

1. **Extinguishes wind; stops spasms**
2. **Stops itching**
3. **Transforms phlegm**
4. **Dissipates nodules**
5. **Benefits throat**

Key Indications

- Facial paralysis
- Wind-phlegm seizures
- Scrofula
- Skin itching

Cautions/Contraindications

- None major

Preparation

- Usually dry-fried.

Dosage

- 3–10 g

Exam Pearl

Wind herb that also transforms phlegm.

Dì Lóng 地龙

Pheretima | *Earthworm*

Nature & Flavor: Salty, cold

Channels: Liver, Lung, Bladder, Spleen

Primary Actions

1. **Clears heat; extinguishes wind**
2. **Unblocks channels; treats Bi and stroke**
3. **Arrests wheezing**
4. **Promotes urination**

Key Indications

- High fever with convulsions
- Asthma with Lung heat
- Bi syndrome with heat
- Post-stroke paralysis
- Urinary obstruction

Cautions/Contraindications

- Cold nature—use cautiously in cold patterns

Preparation

- Decoction or fresh preparation.

Dosage

- 5–10 g decoction
- 1–2 g powder

Exam Pearl

Only wind herb that arrests wheezing

Shí Jué Míng 石决明

Concha Haliotidis | *Abalone shell*

Nature & Flavor: Salty, cold

Channels: Liver

Primary Actions

1. **Anchors yang**
2. **Calms Liver**
3. **Clears Liver heat**
4. **Brightens eyes**

Key Indications

- Liver yang rising with headache and dizziness
- Red painful eyes
- Blurred vision due to Liver heat or yin deficiency

Cautions/Contraindications

- Use cautiously in Spleen deficiency with loose stools

Preparation

- Crush and pre-decoct to extract minerals

Dosage

- 15–30 g

Exam Pearl

Heavy mineral that anchors Liver yang and treats eye disorders from Liver fire.

Mǔ Lì 牡蛎

Concha Ostreae | *Oyster shell*

Nature & Flavor: Salty, astringent, cool

Channels: Liver, Kidney

Primary Actions

1. **Anchors Liver yang; calms Shen**
2. **Softens hardness; prevents leakage**
3. **Astringes leakage (fluids and essence)**
4. **Neutralizes stomach acid**

Key Indications

- Yin deficiency with ascendant yang
- Goiter or scrofula
- Night sweating or spermatorrhea
- Acid reflux and stomach pain

Cautions/Contraindications

- Use cautiously in Spleen deficiency cold

Preparation

- Calcined (Duan Mu Li): Neutralizes stomach acid; astringent
- Crush and pre-decoct

Dosage

- 15–30 g

Exam Pearl

Three functions: anchor yang, soften nodules, prevent leakage.

Dài Zhě Shí 代赭石

Haematitum | *Hematite*

Nature & Flavor: Bitter, cold

Channels: Heart, Liver

Primary Actions

1. **Anchors floating yang; clears LV fire**
2. **Strongly redirects rebellious qi downward**
3. **Cools blood; stops bleeding**

Key Indications

- Liver yang rising with dizziness
- Vomiting, hiccups, belching
- Asthma with rebellious qi
- Hematemesis or epistaxis

Cautions/Contraindications

- Pregnancy; cold conditions; prolonged use
- Use cautiously due to heavy mineral toxicity

Preparation

- Crush and pre-decoct.

Dosage

- 10–30 g (severe cases up to 60–90 g)

Exam Pearl

Best herb for rebellious qi with Liver yang rising.

Ci Ji Li/Bái Jí Lí 白蒺藜

Fructus Tribuli | *Tribulus fruit*

Nature & Flavor: Acrid, bitter, neutral

Channels: Liver

Primary Actions

1. **Calms Liver yang and soothes Liver**
2. **Moves Liver Qi; disperses stagnation**
3. **Dispels wind; stops itching**
4. **Brightens eyes**

Key Indications

- Liver qi stagnation with flank pain
- Itchy skin disorders (eczema, hives)
- Red swollen eyes
- Hypertension with dizziness

Cautions/Contraindications

- None major

Preparation

- Salt-fried to enhance Liver/Kidney channel entry.

Dosage

- 6–10 g

Exam Pearl

Wind herb that treats itching and Liver qi stagnation.

Jué Míng Zǐ 决明子

Semen Cassiae | *Cassia seed*

Nature & Flavor: Bitter, sweet, cool

Channels: Liver, Large Intestine

Primary Actions

1. **Clears Liver heat**
2. **Brightens eyes**
3. **Anchors Liver yang**
4. **Moistens Intestines**

Key Indications

- Red painful eyes
- Liver yang hypertension
- Constipation from dryness
- Hyperlipidemia

Cautions/Contraindications

- May cause loose stools in weak digestion

Preparation

- Often dry-fried before decoction.

Dosage

- 6–10 g

Exam Pearl

Eye herb that also treats constipation.

Zhen Zhu 珍珠

Margarita | *Pearl*

Nature & Flavor: sweet, salty, cold

Channels: Heart, Liver

Primary Actions

1. **Sedates the Heart, Calms the Shen**
2. **Settles tremors**
3. **Clears Liver heat affecting the eyes**
4. **Promotes tissue regeneration**

Key Indications

- Palpitations and restlessness
- Childhood convulsions
- Chronic ulcers or skin lesions
- Eye disorders (topical use as eye drops)

Cautions/Contraindications

- Primarily used in powder form due to its hardness

Preparation

- Usually used as powder or pill, rarely decocted.

Dosage

- 0.3–1 g

Exam Pearl

- Pearl calms the Heart and regenerates tissue.

High-Yield Comparisons

- **Gou Teng vs. Tian Ma:** Heat/wind vs. mixed etiologies
 - **Shi Jue Ming vs. Mu Li:** Eye focus vs. leakage/nodules
 - **Quan Xie/Wu Gong:** Strong, toxic—reserved for severe cases
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